

Fanny's hands went numb and moments later she suffered a massive stroke. She died the following day, aged only 41. When he heard the news, Felix screamed in anguish and then fainted. For many years, Fanny was little more than a footnote in musical history, but from the later 20th century her work has been gradually rediscovered. About 500 compositions by her are known, including piano music, songs, chamber works, and choral pieces—always beautifully crafted, often lyrical in mood but sometimes stormy.

Discoveries continue to be made. The manuscript of a piano piece known as the “Easter Sonata,” found in a bookstore in France in 1970, is signed “F. Mendelssohn” and is a work of such distinction that it was assumed to be by Felix. However, in 2010, a US musicologist proved that the manuscript had been cut from an album of Fanny's compositions, and in 2012 it was performed for the first time as her work.